conversation and little action. It's unlikely that *Anek* will come even close to making the Rs 65 crore the conscientious and compelling *Article 15*, their last collaboration, did.

For Khurrana, though, the process is the prize. He is proud that his fellow protagonist in the film, Andrea Kevichusa, an actress from Nagaland, was given not only a significant arc by Sinha, but also sufficient screen time. "It is historic [in Hindi cinema]," he says. "In fact, 70 per cent of the cast is from the region. Anubhav has helped pass on the mic to Northeasterners to talk about their struggle."

Regardless of its fate, *Anek* demonstrates Khurrana's eagerness to walk a road less taken. At times, this leads him to an ideal destination—like it did with Sriram Raghavan's dark comedy *Andhadhun* (2018)—but sometimes the experimentation doesn't have the desired effect, as is the case with *Anek*. One cannot, however, hold against Khurrana, the star, his desire to be different from his peers. "When I do niche films, I make sure my remuneration is such that it has to be a successful venture," he says. "I'd also love to do more commercial films because the masses enjoy what is easy to relate to and consume." His directors' wish-list offers a glimpse of his varied taste—there's Rohit Shetty there, Zoya Akhtar and also independent filmmaker Neeraj Ghaywan (*Masaan*, 2015).

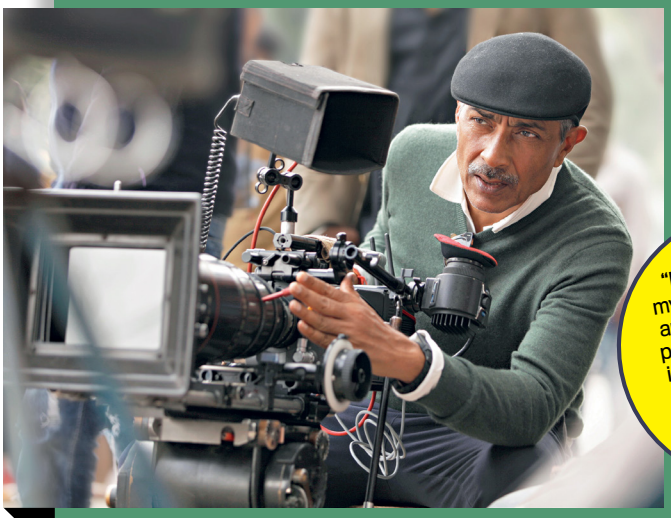
In his pursuit of the novel, Khurrana is also looking toward streaming. He wants a part that might compare to that of 'The Professor' in *Money Heist* (2017-2021). So, have any offers come his way? "I read 10 scripts a day but most are trash," he smiles. "In a year, you find two good scripts. It's a tedious exercise." But he isn't complaining. He knows how rewarding even that one script can become. ■

–Suhani Singh

INTERVIEW

KEEPING THE REEL REAL

AS THE THIRD SEASON OF HIS HIT MX PLAYER SHOW *AASHRAM* DROPS ON JUNE 3, FILMMAKER **PRAKASH JHA** TALKS TO US ABOUT HIS SEVERAL LOVES AND PASSIONS—BHOPAL, POLITICS, THE PIANO AND PAINTING



"I've always found my stories in real life; and the moment you pick something that's in the public domain, you can expect people to have opposing views"

Q. Did you enjoy revisiting the world of *Aashram* the third time around?
I enjoy every step of filmmaking from writing to shooting and post-production. I never analyse the subject or evaluate how I feel about it because then I'll get stuck in my head. Everything about *Aashram* has been fun. The third chapter brings growth—the baba (played by Bobby Deol) grows in stature. His size, his ashram, his people, his greed, his megalomania—all of it will grow till, eventually, he falls.

Q. Last year when you were shooting the third season in Bhopal, you were attacked by members of the Bajrang Dal. Did you find yourself self-censoring after that incident?
Not at all. When this happened, we were close to completing the shoot, so there was no question of changing anything. I have always found my stories in real life; and the moment you pick something that's in the public domain, you can expect people to have opposing views. As long as you aren't hurting anyone personally, you just tell your story and move on. That day, when these 50-60 people came with their sticks and stones, I was only concerned that there shouldn't be any violence because I had a crew of over 300 people. Once they left, we carried on with our work.

Q. Your love for Madhya Pradesh, and specially Bhopal, is well known. Did this experience sour that fondness?
Immediately after the incident, the local administration, the police and civil society turned up where we were shooting to show their support. We shot there for a few more weeks and it was all peaceful.

Q. You are going to be directing a series on the life of the late P.V. Narasimha Rao. What about his life intrigued you?
This is a period in India's political history that fascinates me. Most of my films are based around the time of the open market economy and Mandal commission, so when the proposal came to me, I couldn't let go. This is a story about a man whom no one considers a hero. Even his own party dumped him. He changed India in many, many ways. His story excites and fascinates me.

Q. A few years ago, you had talked about dabbling in painting and wanting to learn to play the piano. How is that going?
I have a half-finished canvas in my bedroom, but I haven't been very regular with the piano lessons I started during lockdown. I have hope, though, of doing all of these things and more. ■

–with Karishma Upadhyay